

Seeing racial avoidance on New York City streets

Ben Berton

MSc Science, Technology, & Policy

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Research Question



- Do pedestrians avoid racial out-group members?
- Focus on reactions to Black men in public sidewalks
- Outcome of interest
 - Spatial movement, not attitudes

Why It Matters



- Microaggressions in everyday spaces
- Bias beyond self-reported attitudes
- Public behavior as social signal
 - Reflects how comfortable or threatened people feel
- Connects to implicit bias and discrimination

Experimental Design



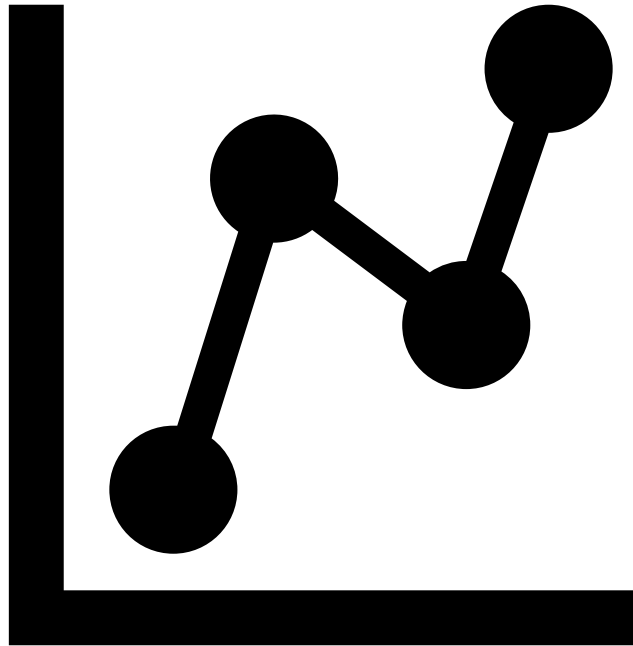
- Field experiment, not lab-based
- Locations
 - Midtown (busy, mixed demographics)
 - Upper East Side (wealthier, whiter)
- 45-minute randomized time blocks
- Three conditions:
 - Two white confederates
 - Two Black confederates
 - No confederates (baseline)

Why These Design Choices?



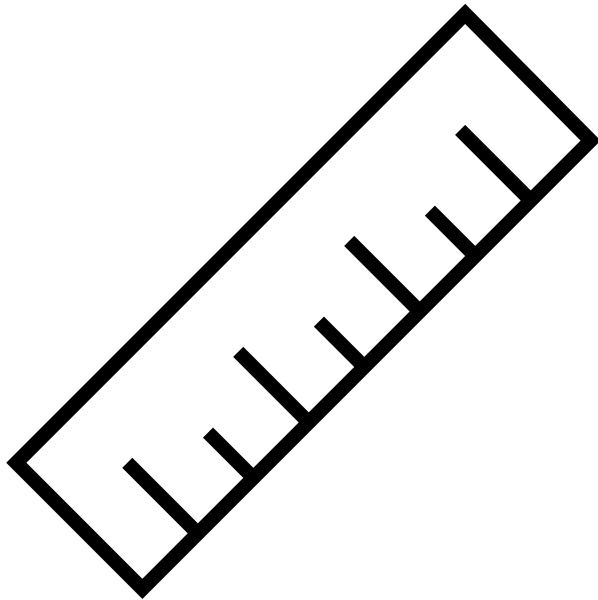
- NYC
 - Dense pedestrian traffic
- Public sidewalks
 - Pedestrians don't know they are in a study
- Short blocks
 - Avoid spillover and time bias differences caused by rush hour vs. quieter times
- Baseline condition
 - Isolates confederate effect

Data & Measurement



- 5,408 pedestrians observed
- Video from live traffic cameras
- Paths traced using ImageJ
 - Frame-by-frame from camera footage
- Outcome
 - SPD (standardized pedestrian deviation)
 - % sidewalk width shifted away from confederates

Who Was Excluded?



- No kids, groups, runners, or distracted walkers
- Only solo walkers
- Black-identifying pedestrians analyzed separately
 - Racial-avoidance question focuses on out-group reactions
- Goal
 - Isolate behavior of out-group reactions

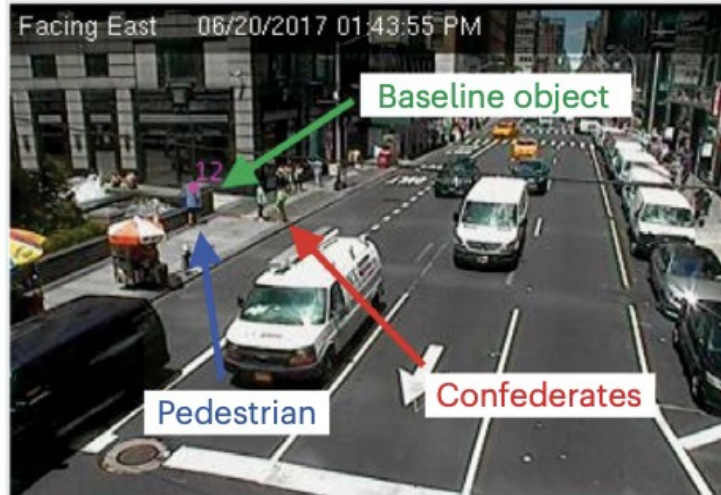
Methods & Analysis



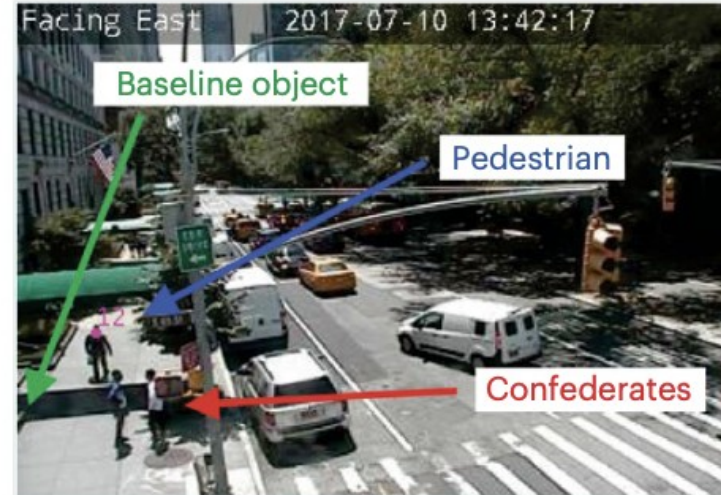
- Average Treatment Effect (ATE)
 - Raw mean differences
- Controlled Treatment Effect (CTE)
 - Linear Regression
 - Accounts for
 - Pedestrian traits (race, gender estimate, age)
 - Time block fixed effects

Design & Data

a Midtown set-up



b Upper East Side set-up



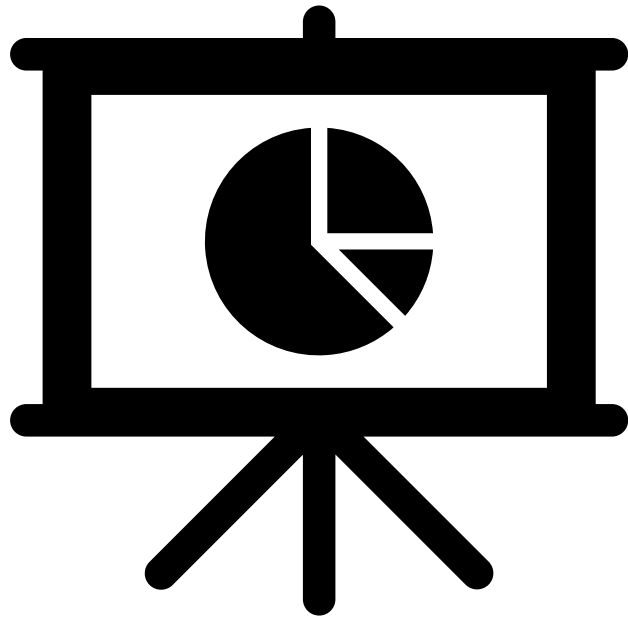
c Midtown example



d Upper East Side example

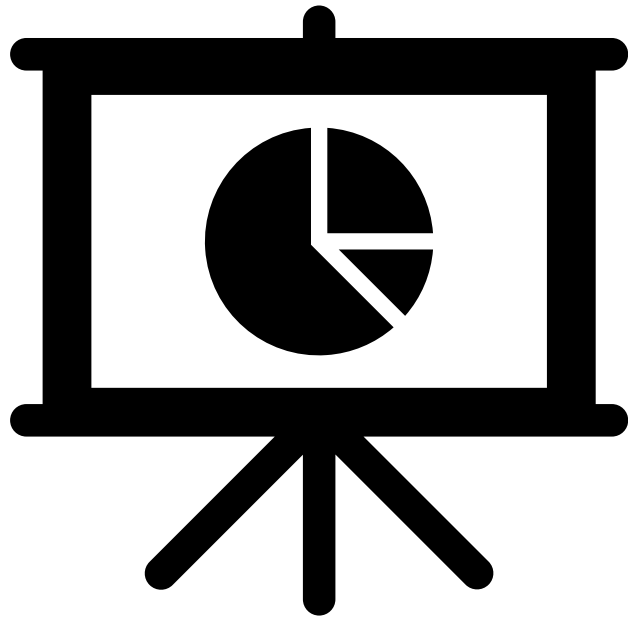


Main Results



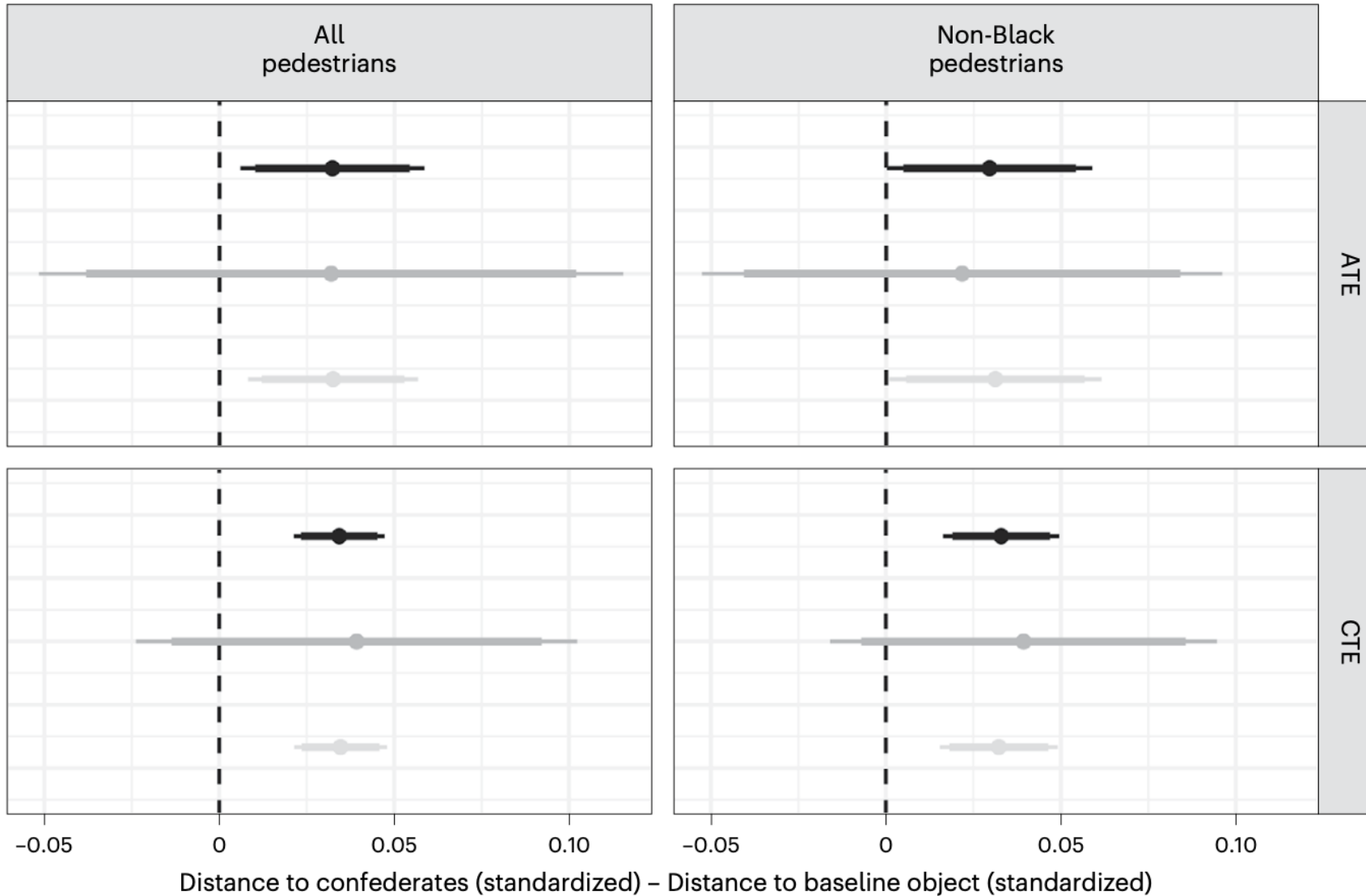
- ~3 – 4% more distance from Black confederates
- ~4 inches on average
- Stronger in Midtown
- Upper East Side: smaller sample
 - Not significant

Subgroup Insights



- Women deviate more overall (not only for race)
- Baseline condition shows pedestrians don't naturally space widely

Exhibit: Figure 2



Key:

Black = Both locations

Dark Grey = Upper East Side

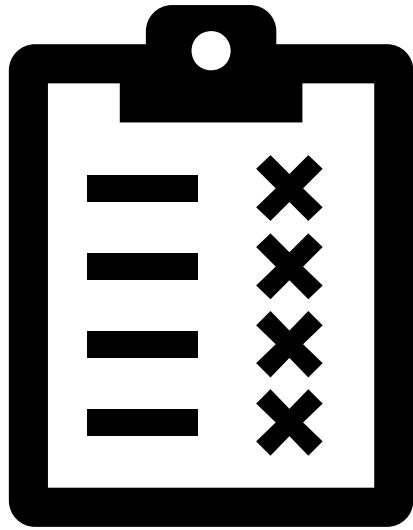
Light Grey = Midtown

Are Results Convincing?



- Strengths
 - Real-world behavior
 - Large sample size
 - Robust analysis
 - ATE and CTE

Are Results Convincing?



- Limitations
 - Only male confederates
 - Only two neighborhoods
 - Pedestrians are likely to be wealthier, better educated and more politically left-leaning
 - Interpretation of movement ambiguous

Link to Class Concepts



- Public admin data as research tool
 - Reflects rise of big-data-based social science
- Ethics debates
 - Links to our discussions on surveillance and consent

Broader Implications - Research



- Method allows researchers to study mass pedestrian behavior in the real world
- Method can extend to gender, age, class, religion
- Combines surveillance tech and experimentation

Broader Implications - Policy & Social Implications

- Subtle racial distancing affects daily life
 - Reinforces inequality in invisible ways.
- Reflects micro-level segregation

Broader Implications - Ethics

- No consent due to public setting
 - Legally allowed, but morally gray
- Individuals not identified
 - Faces not tracked
- Still raises surveillance concerns
- Normalizes tracking human movement.

Discussion Questions



- Should institutions act on this kind of finding?
- Is using public camera footage without consent ethically acceptable?
- Should research using public surveillance require new rules?

Questions?

References

1. Dietrich, B. J., & Sands, M. L. (2023). Seeing racial avoidance on New York City streets. *Nature Human Behaviour*, 7(8), 1275–1281. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-023-01589-7>

Ben Berton

Student - MSc Science, Technology, & Policy